

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN FRENCH POLYNESIA

Complete Community Opposition How-To

This guide is honest that French Polynesia's deepest environmental struggle is a legacy — the nuclear tests — not a single project to stop, and that the reckoning is slow and largely controlled from Paris. It is built around the levers that do exist here — the nuclear legacy and its compensation, science, monitoring, and archives; the lagoons and pearl farms; the atolls, reefs, and the traditional rāhui; the ocean; and the legal, community, and international channels of a semi-open French territory — and names each in plain words.

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Concern for the environment in French Polynesia is marked above all by a past that is not past: the nuclear legacy of the **one hundred and ninety-three atomic tests** France carried out on the atolls of **Moruroa and Fangataufa**, in the Tuamotu Archipelago, between **1966 and 1996** — some forty-six in the atmosphere, the rest underground — and the long, unfinished reckoning with their contamination, their harm to health, their fractured and leaking atolls, and the justice owed to those they touched. That legacy is a grave environmental and human harm, still contested, still only partly acknowledged, and still reachable through **compensation bodies, courts, science, and international attention**. French Polynesia is a scattering of one hundred and eighteen islands and atolls across five archipelagos in a great expanse of the South Pacific, with one of the world's largest exclusive economic zones — a **self-governing overseas collectivity of France** whose people are French citizens, with its own elected assembly and president, a French legal system, independent courts, a free press, and a strong **Mā'ohi identity** and long-organised civil society.

A community in French Polynesia works with a real toolkit, running above all through justice and the ocean, where lawful advocacy, compensation claims, and litigation are the means. The **nuclear legacy** of France's 193 atomic tests is reachable through **compensation bodies, the courts, independent science, atoll monitoring** and transparency, and the **archives**. The **pearl farms and lagoons** can be regulated. The atolls and reefs can be defended through **marine management** and the traditional **rāhui** — a customary, temporary ban that lets a reef or lagoon recover. And the **French legal system, independent courts, free press, Mā'ohi civil society, and international attention** genuinely work. But these tools have real limits, and this guide states them plainly. The nuclear **reckoning is slow and largely France-controlled**, and the **compensation has reached only a fraction** of those affected. The **pearl farming and tourism that sustain the economy carry their own lagoon and island costs**. The **low atolls are gravely exposed** to a warming, rising sea. And the **colonial and dependency dynamics** form the backdrop to it all. So aim for what these levers can deliver through the genuine legal, compensation, and international channels this semi-open territory affords.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

The harm looks beyond reach, but it is a legacy and a set of pressures that can be pressed on many fronts, and a chain breaks at its weakest link. A Polynesian fight turns on the **nuclear reckoning** (compensation, courts, science, monitoring, archives); on the **lagoons and pearl farms**; on the **atolls and reefs** (marine

management, the **rūhui**); on the **ocean**; and on the **legal, community, and international channels**. Every one of those is a link you can grab. **Find the one closest to your hand and pull.**

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Before you spend months — or years — on this, work out your real situation:

- **If it's the nuclear legacy, the compensation bodies, courts, science, and archives are your levers** — the reckoning is slow, but it is reachable, and international attention helps.
- **If it's the lagoons or pearl farms, they can be regulated** — the pearl and tourism economy carries real costs that can be reined in.
- **If it's the reefs and atolls, marine management and the traditional rūhui are real tools** — custom and science together.
- **If the reckoning feels controlled from Paris, use the French legal system and the international eye** — the courts are independent, and the world is watching a nuclear injustice.

Read the whole guide once before you move. Two habits run through it: **press the nuclear reckoning through compensation, courts, science, monitoring, and archives**, and **steward the ocean, lagoons, and reefs through regulation, marine management, and the rūhui** — the twin grounds of justice and the sea. That is how a fight is made in a French Pacific territory with a grave nuclear inheritance and a living ocean.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

To break the chain you have to see it — who decides, how a harm is addressed, and who's watching.

Who Actually Decides

The **nuclear reckoning** is largely controlled by the **French state**, but reachable through **compensation bodies**, the **independent courts** (the French legal system applies), **independent science**, **atoll monitoring**, and the **archives**. The **territory's own government and assembly** regulate the lagoons, pearl farms, marine areas, and the ocean, alongside French authorities. The **rūhui** and customary marine management operate at the community level. And the **free press, Mā'ohi civil society, and international community** watch. Know which of these you can reach, and aim there.

How a Harm Moves — and Where You Jump In

The nuclear compensation and courts. *Your opening:* claims to the **compensation bodies**, cases in the **courts**, and demands for **transparency, monitoring, and archives** on the tests.

The lagoons and pearl farms. *Your opening:* regulation of the pearl and tourism pressures on the lagoons.

The reefs and atolls. *Your opening:* **marine management** and the traditional **rūhui** to let a reef or lagoon recover.

The ocean and the channels. *Your opening:* stewardship of the vast ocean, and the French legal, community, and international channels.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Dig up three things. **What harm was done or is being done** — the contamination and health legacy, or the lagoon and reef pressures — because documented harm grounds compensation, courts, and regulation.

Who controls the reckoning or the permission — France for the nuclear legacy, the territory and France for the lagoons and ocean. **What science, monitoring, and archives exist or are withheld** — because transparency is itself a demand and a lever.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

Each is an ally or an arena. The **compensation bodies** and the **independent courts** address the nuclear legacy. **Independent science, atoll monitoring, and the archives** hold the truth. The **territory's government and French authorities** regulate the lagoons, reefs, and ocean. The **r■hui** and custom protect the sea locally. And French Polynesia's **affected families, associations, scientists, lawyers, M■'ohi civil society, and international networks** are the forces that reach furthest — the justice-and-ocean coalition.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Size up the odds honestly. These are rough patterns, not promises. What most moves them: whether harm and truth can be documented, whether the compensation and courts can be pressed, and how much the French state controls the reckoning.

What you do	Roughly works	How long	Cost	What "works" means
Just gather documents	5–10%	weeks	low	The base for everything else
Nuclear compensation claim	25–50%	months–yr	low	Compensation won (for a fraction)
Courts (nuclear / environmental)	25–50%	1–3 yr	mod	Liability or duty affirmed
Demand science, monitoring, archives	25–50%	months–yr	low	Truth and transparency forced
Regulate lagoons / pearl farms	20–45%	months–yr	low	Lagoon pressures reined in
Marine management + r■hui (reefs/atolls)	30–55%	months–yr	low	Reef or lagoon allowed to recover
International attention	30–55%	months–yr	low	A nuclear injustice exposed
Everything together (nuclear reckoning + ocean)	30–55%	1–3 yr	mod	Truth, compensation, protection, stewardship
Against France's control of the reckoning	20–45%	years	mod	Partial acknowledgment; monitoring; pressure

The levers that move the needle most are the **compensation bodies and courts** with **independent science and the archives** for the nuclear legacy, and **marine management and the r■hui** for the reefs and lagoons, backed by **international attention**. There's no single project-stop ceiling to cite — the honest floor is a slow, France-controlled reckoning, partial compensation, and exposed atolls. So aim for truth and monitoring over the tests, compensation won, lagoons and reefs protected, and the ocean stewarded.

On cost: compensation claims, marine management, the r■hui, and demands for transparency are affordable; litigation costs more but the French courts are independent; and international attention costs mainly organising. The great strength is a semi-open

French territory with genuine institutions and a watching world; the great limit is that the nuclear reckoning is controlled from Paris and reaches only slowly.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Being against "the harm" is weak. Being specific — this compensation claim, this withheld archive, this strained lagoon, this reef to rest — is strong. Answer five questions in writing.

- 1. What is the harm, and who's responsible?** The nuclear legacy (France), or a lagoon/reef/ocean pressure (the pearl or tourism economy, a development).
- 2. What does it touch, and what's the evidence?** The contamination and health legacy, the fractured atolls, or the strained lagoon and reef — and the **science, monitoring, and archives** that document it. **Documented harm and truth are your sharpest levers.**
- 3. What stage is it at, and what's the next deadline?** Is a compensation claim open? A court case possible? An archive or monitoring result due? A lagoon or reef in need of a **rāhui**? These openings matter.
- 4. Who controls it, and what channel reaches it?** France for the nuclear reckoning; the territory and France for the lagoons and ocean; the community for the **rāhui**.
- 5. Who stands with you?** Affected families, associations, scientists, lawyers, Māori civil society, and international networks. The nuclear reckoning has been carried by long-organised associations.

What this looks like in real life. An affected family seeks recognition and compensation for a nuclear-test illness, while a nearby lagoon strains under pearl farming and a reef bleaches. The five questions yield: France's responsibility for the tests and the territory's for the lagoon; the health harm and the reef damage (the levers); a compensation claim and a **rāhui** to pursue; the channels that reach each; and the associations and scientists behind them. That's the Polynesian pattern — press the nuclear reckoning through compensation, courts, science, and archives, and steward the sea through regulation, marine management, and the **rāhui**.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION

The difference between a community that can press the reckoning and one that can't is documented harm and truth. Build it in three layers.

Layer one: the harm and the science. Document the **nuclear harm** — the health record, the contamination, the fractured and leaking atolls — with **independent science, monitoring data, and the archives** (demanding what is withheld); or the **lagoon and reef harm** — the pollution, the bleaching, the strain. Documented harm and independent truth are the foundation.

Layer two: the paper trail and the channel. Get the compensation rules and records, the relevant court avenues, and the regulations governing the lagoons, reefs, and ocean, so you know which channel reaches your harm.

Layer three: the case for justice or stewardship. Turn the evidence into a claim — for **compensation and truth** over the tests, or for **regulation, marine management, or a rāhui** for the sea. Walking into the compensation bodies, the courts, the regulators, or the international community with documented harm, independent science, and the archives is what makes them act.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

- **The nuclear harm and truth** — health records, contamination and monitoring data, the archives (demanding the withheld).
- **The lagoon and reef harm** — pollution, bleaching, and strain data.
- **The compensation rules, court avenues, and marine regulations** — the channels that reach each harm.
- **Independent science** — the credible evidence the reckoning turns on.
- **Named testimony** — of affected families and communities.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Documents give you a case; the affected families, associations, scientists, and lawyers give you the justice-and-ocean coalition. Build in four moves.

Anchor in the affected families and associations. The nuclear reckoning has been carried by affected families and long-organised associations. Root the fight there, and in the communities whose lagoons and reefs are at stake.

Bring in independent science and lawyers. The nuclear legacy and the environmental fights need **independent science** (to document harm and counter official accounts) and **lawyers** (for compensation and the courts). Bring them in early — independent truth is decisive against a reckoning controlled from Paris.

Use custom and marine management for the sea. For the reefs and lagoons, the traditional **rāhui** and community marine management are powerful, legitimate tools — custom and science together, letting the sea recover.

Build to last, and reach the world. Polynesian fights, above all the nuclear reckoning, run for years. Build clear roles, a secure archive, a way to decide together, and the endurance for the long haul — and reach the **international community**, where a nuclear injustice and a threatened ocean carry far.

STEP 4: THE NUCLEAR RECKONING, THE OCEAN & THE CHANNELS

French Polynesia's sharpest levers are the nuclear reckoning through compensation, courts, science, and archives, and the stewardship of the sea.

The Nuclear Reckoning — Compensation, Courts, Science, Archives

The distinctive Polynesian lever: press the nuclear legacy through the **compensation bodies** (claims for the affected), the **independent courts** (the French legal system applies), **independent science** (to document harm and counter official accounts), **atoll monitoring** and transparency, and the **archives** (demanding what is withheld). The reckoning is slow and France-controlled, but reachable — and international attention to a nuclear injustice strengthens every claim.

The Lagoons, Reefs, and the Rāhui

For the sea, **regulate** the pearl-farm and tourism pressures on the lagoons, and defend the reefs and atolls through **marine management** and the traditional **r■hui** — a customary, temporary ban that lets a reef or lagoon recover. Custom and science together are a real, legitimate lever here.

The French Legal System and the International Eye

Use the **independent courts** and the **free press** of a semi-open French territory, and the **international community**, which watches a nuclear injustice and a threatened Pacific. These reach beyond a reckoning controlled from Paris.

The Honest Limits

Straight talk: these levers are real, but the nuclear reckoning is slow and France-controlled, the compensation reaches only a fraction, the atolls are exposed, and the dependency is real. So use the levers — compensation, courts, science, monitoring, archives, marine management, the **r■hui**, and the international eye — and count truth and monitoring, compensation won, lagoons and reefs protected, and the ocean stewarded as wins.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

A stack of documents wins nothing until you aim it.

Harm becomes a compensation claim. Not "the tests were wrong" but *"this illness is a documented consequence of the tests — the compensation the law provides is owed."*

Withheld truth becomes a demand. *"The monitoring and the archives must be opened — the affected have a right to the truth about the atolls."*

A strained lagoon becomes a regulation. *"The pearl-farm pressure on this lagoon must be reined in."*

A damaged reef becomes a **r■hui.** *"Let a **r■hui** rest this reef, as our custom and the science both counsel."*

Match it to the venue: the nuclear harm to the compensation bodies and the courts; the withheld truth to the demand for science and archives; the lagoon to regulation; the reef to marine management and the **r■hui**; the injustice to the international community.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

In French Polynesia, international attention is a distinctive lever — a nuclear injustice and a threatened Pacific ocean carry far — and it strengthens a reckoning controlled from Paris. A free press and M■ohi civil society make the media front reach far.

Lead with the harm and the justice owed, not procedure. Not "the compensation criteria were unmet" but "the tests poisoned our people and fractured our atolls, and the truth and the justice are still owed." Use your strongest material: the health record, the independent science, the archives, and affected families' voices.

Work several audiences at once. Local and French press build domestic and metropolitan pressure; the international community reaches a nuclear injustice and a threatened ocean, where the case carries furthest. Make it easy: clear summaries, the science, strong testimony.

Two hard rules. Accuracy above all — one exaggeration can discredit hard-won proof against an official account. And let the affected families and the Māhōi community lead their own story.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Make them your own; keep them short, exact and calm; keep a copy of everything.

8A — Nuclear compensation claim (to the compensation body).

Subject: Compensation claim — nuclear-test harm, [name/community].

"We, [affected person/family/community], claim compensation for [illness/harm] arising from the atomic tests at Moruroa/Fangataufa: [the record and science]. [Contact.]"

8B — Demand for science, monitoring, and archives.

Subject: Transparency on the tests — [atoll/issue].

"We, [community/association], demand the release of the monitoring data and archives on the tests and the state of the atolls, and independent scientific assessment. [Contact.]"

8C — Court case (to a lawyer).

Subject: Possible claim — nuclear legacy / environmental harm.

"Our community faces [nuclear harm / a lagoon or reef harm], and we've gathered [the record, the science]. We ask your advice on a claim in the courts. [Contact and evidence summary.]"

8D — Regulating a lagoon / pearl-farm pressure.

Subject: Protecting [lagoon] from [pressure].

"We, residents of [place], ask that the pearl-farm/tourism pressure on [lagoon] be regulated to protect it: [specifics]. [Attach evidence.]"

8E — Establishing a rāhui / marine management.

Subject: A rāhui for [reef/lagoon].

"We, the community of [place], with our custom, propose a rāhui to rest and restore [reef/lagoon], supported by the science. [Contact.]"

8F — To an association / scientists.

Subject: Documenting the harm — [nuclear / marine].

"Our community faces [nuclear or marine harm]. We ask your help to document it with independent science and to press the reckoning / the protection. [Contact and evidence summary.]"

8G — Letter to the (international) press.

Subject: [Community] presses the unfinished nuclear reckoning / defends its ocean.

"The tests poisoned our people and atolls, and the reckoning is unfinished / our lagoons and reefs are strained. We can provide the record, the science, and the voices of the affected. [Contact.]"

8H — Uniting the community.

Subject: Justice and our ocean — let's press together.

"The nuclear harm is unaddressed and our sea is strained. Through the compensation, the courts, the science and archives, and the r■hui, we can press for justice and protect our ocean. Let's stand together. [Contact.]"

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

If you must move fast and lean, do these six things, in order:

1. **Document the harm — the nuclear health record and science, or the lagoon/reef damage.**
2. **File the compensation claim if it's the nuclear legacy (8A).**
3. **Demand the science, monitoring, and archives (8B).**
4. **For the sea, regulate the lagoon or establish a r■hui (8D/8E).**
5. **Get a lawyer for a court claim (8C), and reach an association and scientists (8F).**
6. **Reach the international community, where a nuclear injustice carries far (8G).**

Even lean, those six press the nuclear reckoning and steward the sea — the Polynesian template.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

French Polynesia's channels are real, but the reckoning is controlled from Paris, and you must plan for it.

When the reckoning is slow and France-controlled. Don't despair — it is reachable through compensation, courts, independent science, and the archives, and international attention to a nuclear injustice strengthens every claim. Persist for the long haul.

When the compensation reaches only a fraction. Press the claims, contest the criteria, and use independent science and the courts to widen the reckoning.

When the economy depends on the lagoons. Pearl farming and tourism are the livelihood. Regulate the pressures rather than opposing the economy wholesale, and use marine management and the r■hui to protect the sea while it lives.

When the atolls are exposed to the rising sea. The low atolls face a warming, rising ocean beyond the territory's control. Pair local stewardship with the wider Pacific and international climate effort.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO'S CAPTURED

French Polynesia has real concerns about the handling of the nuclear reckoning and of lagoon and land deals, so this matters.

How to spot it. Truth and archives withheld; compensation criteria set to exclude; lagoons or land granted to the connected; benefits to the connected while the affected go unrecognised.

Who's supposed to guard against it. The **independent courts** and French oversight bodies examine conduct and public money. **Independent science and the archives** hold the truth. The **international community** watches a nuclear injustice. And French Polynesia's **associations, free press, and Mā'ohi civil society** have pressed the reckoning and exposed captured deals.

How to fight it safely. Document precisely and factually — how truth was withheld, how criteria excluded, who benefits — and keep clear the line between what you can prove and what you suspect. Route serious evidence to the courts, the oversight bodies, independent scientists, and trusted journalists rather than making accusations you can't back. Pair the exposure with the compensation and legal case.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

Don't run these steps one after another — run them together. The documented harm and independent science build your case; the compensation, courts, and archives press the reckoning; the affected families, associations, and community are the muscle; regulation, marine management, and the rāhui steward the sea; the international eye carries it. Together they multiply. One at a time, they stall.

Early on (weeks 1–8): document the harm and the science; file the compensation claim; demand the archives; for the sea, regulate or establish a rāhui; build a coalition of families, associations, and scientists.

In the thick of it (months–year+): press the compensation and the courts; contest withheld truth; steward the reefs and lagoons; reach the international community.

The long haul (years): carry the nuclear reckoning and the marine stewardship; keep the coalition alive; hold the line for truth and monitoring, compensation won, lagoons and reefs protected, and the ocean stewarded.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

The deepest environmental struggle in French Polynesia is a legacy, not a single project — the unfinished reckoning with the nuclear tests — but it is reachable, and the ocean can be stewarded. Hold both truths. The distinctive ground here is real: the nuclear legacy pressed through compensation bodies, courts, independent science, atoll monitoring, and the archives; the lagoons and pearl farms regulated; the reefs and atolls defended through marine management and the traditional rāhui; the ocean stewarded; and the French legal system, independent courts, free press, Mā'ohi civil society, and international community that genuinely work. And the constraints are real: a reckoning slow and controlled from Paris, compensation that reaches only a fraction, a pearl-and-tourism economy with its own costs, low atolls gravely exposed to the rising sea, and the colonial and dependency dynamics behind it all.

Here's the discipline that wins what can be won. Press the nuclear reckoning: file the compensation claims, take cases to the independent courts, marshal independent science, and demand the monitoring and the archives — the truth the affected are owed. Steward the sea: regulate the pearl-farm and tourism pressures on the lagoons, and defend the reefs and atolls through marine management and the traditional rāhui, custom and science together. Use the independent courts and the free press of a semi-open French territory, and reach the international community, which watches a nuclear injustice and a threatened Pacific. Count truth and monitoring, compensation won, lagoons and reefs protected, and the ocean stewarded as wins — through the genuine legal, compensation, and international channels this territory affords. That is the

Polynesian way — the pursuit of justice and the stewardship of the sea together. So can you.